At the Army House in Delhi, General Thapar was not yet aware of the developments in Bum-la. His mind was preoccupied with what the DMO, Brigadier Palit, had said to him the previous evening. Until now, Tawang had been declared vital ground, but he knew he had erred badly by not allowing 7 Brigade to pull back when Bijji Kaul had rather forcefully stated his case on 11 October. As the COAS, he knew the debacle at Nam Ka Chu would ultimately be laid at his feet. Early on the morning of 23 October, he called Palit and asked him to join the meeting with the prime minister and the defence minister. Palit quickly prepared a written analysis of the tactical alternatives, in case the prime minister or the defence minister asked for it, collected his maps, and presented himself at Menon's office to await the chief.

In the defence minister's room, Nehru, Menon and the foreign secretary, M. J. Desai, were seated around a table where they were joined by Thapar. The COAS told Nehru that his DMO, who had previously commanded 7 Brigade and was well acquainted with the terrain, had some important points to make on the developing Kameng situation. Palit unfolded a map and began to describe the tactical situation in Tawang, in particular emphasizing the tracks from Bum-la that bypassed Tawang and led to Se-la directly. 'What is it that you wish to convey?' a pale and subdued Nehru asked Palit.

'Tawang is not a suitable area in which to site the main defences. The Chinese could entrap the garrison and move into central Kameng without attacking Tawang. What the army desires is permission to withdraw from the Tawang salient and to hold a defensive position further back, because if we continue to hold on to Tawang with the only troops we have available, the Chinese would before long be making for the Brahmaputra plains via the undefended Manda-la.'

Palit stressed that the decision to evacuate Tawang had to be taken immediately. Menon had sat through the briefing with a scowl on his face, showing no interest in the discussion. Nehru turned to Thapar and said: 'It is now for the military to decide where and how they should fight. I have no doubt in my mind that what we lose, you shall eventually win back for us. I cannot lay down conditions about Tawang or any other place on grounds other than military.' Palit left the defence minister's room and proceeded directly to the Ops Room from where he issued orders to stop all forward moves of units belonging to 62 and 48 Infantry Brigades beyond Dirang. He